

Contrarian Winning Strategy for Zero to Agent

Executive summary

The first batch likely over-optimized **how to build** and underweighted **why people pick winners**. In Zero to Agent, the hard constraints are solo-only, one submission, live-on-, and a one-day vote window, while winners are chosen by both community votes and the Vercel team. At the same time, the public showcase on April 25 only shows two visible projects: a travel planner and a skincare tool. That means the real edge is not “more AI”; it is a **painkiller agent with obvious utility, visible proof, and a pre-built vote funnel**.

My recommendation is to build **OfferProof**: a live agent for students and junior professionals in the that searches live jobs, verifies company footprint, scans recent news, and returns an evidence-backed shortlist with red/yellow/green trust signals. This fits a real local pain: youth employment softness and underemployment remain meaningful, while phishing and risky URLs surged sharply by end-2025. It also fits Gen Z voting behavior because the result is instantly understandable, screenshot-friendly, and useful today.

Hidden edge and competition audit

Thesis

The missing angle is **winner selection psychology**: judges want obvious Vercel-native competence, while voters reward instant usefulness and a memorable screenshot. Official docs emphasize durable workflows, tool calling, structured outputs, live deployment, and real integrations; official templates foreground deep research, human approval, and observable runs. The winning edge is probably not more features. The winning edge is **a narrow agent that makes one high-stakes decision visibly better than a human can do alone**.

Rules edge-case audit

Confirmed rule	Strategic meaning	Practical move	Risk
Solo, one submission	No split-test at the end	Lock concept by Apr 26	Mid-build idea switching
Live, accessible on Vercel	No auth wall, no broken demos	Ship no-auth demo mode	Login friction kills votes
Votes only on May 4 PT	Distribution must be ready before voting opens	Finish assets before submit	“I’ll post later” loses window
Community + Vercel input	Build for both taste and usefulness	Explicitly show v0/Vercel use	Pretty app with weak proof

Confirmed rule	Strategic meaning	Practical move	Risk
PT governs rules	Manila cutoff is not “end of May 3 local”	Treat deadline as May 4 afternoon Manila time	Late submission confusion
Cannot vote for own project	Need outside amplifiers	Prep peer/share list early	Invisible launch

The timing risk is real: during the event window, Manila is UTC+8 while PT is UTC-7, a 15-hour spread. That makes the May 3, 23:59 PT cutoff effectively May 4 afternoon in Manila.

Showcase white-space map

Category	Sat.	Demo	Judge	Vote	Novelty	Risk	Feas.	Move
Travel planners	H	H	M	M	L	M	H	Avoid
Consumer skincare/scan	M	M	M	M	M	L	H	Avoid
Generic productivity	H	L	L	L	L	L	H	Avoid
General research agent	H	M	H	M	L	M	M	Avoid unless niche
Jobs + trust	M	H	H	H	H	M	H	Attack
Scam / trust-safety	M	H	H	H	H	M	H	Attack
Disaster readiness	L	H	H	H	H	H	M	Attack carefully
SME local intel	L	M	H	M	H	M	M	Attack selectively
Creator trend research	M	H	M	H	M	L	H	Selective
Chat-platform bots	M	M	H	L	M	H	L	Avoid
Workflow ops/ approval	M	M	H	L	M	M	M	Back-end angle only

This map is an inference from the current showcase, official Zero to Agent tracks, and official agent templates, plus local need indicators around jobs and scams.

Judge delight matrix

Dimension	Weak	Good	Winning
Technical credibility	Single prompt	Two APIs	Multi-step + typed outputs
Agentic depth	Chat only	Tool use	Retrieval + scoring + approval

Dimension	Weak	Good	Winning
Vercel-native	Hosted app	Next.js deploy	Workflow/AI SDK visibly central
v0 leverage	Boilerplate UI	Fast scaffolding	v0 + polish + deploy story
Reliability	Hope it works	Basic errors	Demo mode + cache + fallback
Novelty	Common niche	Useful niche	Useful + unexpected wedge
Usefulness	"Could help"	Saves time	Prevents bad decisions
Demo clarity	Abstract	Understandable	One screenshot shows payoff
Storytelling	Features list	Problem/solution	Before/after + receipts
Polish	Template look	Branded UI	Production-feeling trust UI
Social proof	None	Likes	Easy replay/share/result card

Official Vercel material repeatedly highlights durable execution, structured outputs, human-in-the-loop, research agents, and direct deployment; that is the probable "judge taste profile."

Vote psychology and the idea field

Filipino audiences are massively reachable on social: DataReportal estimates 90.8 million social media user identities in January 2025 and 95.6 million adult identities by late 2025. Meanwhile, Adobe says nearly half of surveyed consumers used TikTok as a search engine in 2026, and an emerging-market Gen Z study found usage is driven by usefulness, ease, compatibility, and motivation. Translation: the vote winner is the project that looks **useful in five seconds** and feels native to video-first discovery.

Vote-magnet checklist: short name, one-line hook, red/yellow/green output, visible evidence links, "agent is working" timeline, exportable result card, no jargon on first screen, and a CTA framed as "vote if this earned it," not begging.

Anti-obvious Manila / SEA ideas

Rank	Idea	User / pain	Agent + live data	15s hook	Total
1	OfferProof	Students, grads; fake/low-signal jobs	Jobs + Local + News + scoring	"It kills sketchy job posts in 40s."	64
2	ScamSignal	Shoppers, freelancers; scam links/sellers	Search + News + risk card	"Paste a sketchy link; get receipts."	62
3	BarangayReady	Families; storm prep chaos	Local + News + checklist	"Type your barangay; get the plan."	59
4	ClientProof	Freelancers; bad clients	Search + News + footprint score	"Vet a client before the call."	58

Rank	Idea	User / pain	Agent + live data	15s hook	Total
5	RentProof	Renters; hidden area tradeoffs	Local + News + ranked areas	"Don't sign blind."	56
6	CampusRadar	Students; scattered opportunities	Jobs + News + deadlines	"Find real opportunities, not spam."	55
7	MarketSnap	MSMEs; local competitor blind spot	Local + Trends + search summary	"See local demand in one run."	54
8	PricePilot	Gadget buyers; fake deals	Shopping + Search + seller checks	"Cheapest safe buy, not cheapest trap."	53
9	CreatorAngles	Creators; trend overwhelm	Trends + News + briefs	"Trend → content plan with sources."	52
10	EventWingman	Builders; missed meetups	Events + Local + route plan	"Never miss the right meetup."	50
11	VendorScout	Organizers; flaky vendors	Local + reviews + compare	"Shortlist reliable suppliers fast."	49
12	PermitPal	Founders; process confusion	Search + official pages + steps	"Know where to go, what to bring."	47
13	LostTime	Citizens; branch/ service confusion	Local + hours + required docs	"Find the right branch first."	46
14	ClinicMatch	Patients; choice overload	Local + reviews + fit ranking	"Pick the right clinic quicker."	45
15	TruthBoard	Communities; rumor confusion	News + Search + evidence card	"Claim card with receipts."	44

Scoring weighted uniqueness, usefulness, demo power, vote power, technical credibility, feasibility, and sponsor fit; the top cluster is clearly **trust-safety + career/local decisioning**. SerpApi's Local, News, Jobs, and Search products directly support that wedge.

Painkiller vs vitamin test

Idea	Painkiller?	Shareable?	Dangerous if wrong?	Score	Keep
OfferProof	Yes	Yes	Medium	9.4	Keep
ScamSignal	Yes	Yes	Medium	9.1	Keep
BarangayReady	Yes	Yes	High	8.5	Keep with guardrails

Idea	Painkiller?	Shareable?	Dangerous if wrong?	Score	Keep
ClientProof	Yes	Medium	Medium	8.4	Keep
RentProof	Yes	Yes	Medium	8.2	Keep
CampusRadar	Borderline	Yes	Low	8.0	Keep
MarketSnap	Mostly vitamin	Low	Low	7.4	Kill for votes

Agentic proof standard

A winning “real agent” should visibly show at least four of the following: external retrieval, structured scoring, evidence links, multi-step timeline, approval/refinement, saved/exported output, and fallback state. AI SDK supports typed tool calls and typed structured objects; Workflows adds durability and observability; v0 can build full-stack Next.js apps, connect APIs, use MCP, and deploy directly to Vercel.

Idea	Retrieval	Score	Evidence	Approval	Export	Verdict
OfferProof	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	Best proof
ScamSignal	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	Strong
BarangayReady	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	Strong but safety-sensitive

Sponsor leverage, tracks, and the chosen concept

Strongest SerpApi angle

The strongest single endpoint for the chosen wedge is **Google Jobs API** because it returns immediately rankable, structured listings with company, location, schedule signals, descriptions, highlights, and apply options; it also supports cache reuse for identical queries, with cached searches free for one hour. For verification, enrich with Google News and Google Local. This is higher-signal than a generic web search for job discovery.

A hidden-but-real angle: SerpApi now has an open-source hosted MCP server and v0 officially supports bring-your-own MCP servers. That is strong sponsor/track alignment, but for an MVP I would treat it as **stretch**, not core, because runtime MCP friction is a bigger risk than direct API integration.

Contrarian track analysis

Track	Upside	Hidden risk	Verdict
Workflows	Judge-respected reliability, observability, clear Vercel-native story	Overbuilding if you add too many async features	Pick

Track	Upside	Hidden risk	Verdict
v0 + MCPs	Sponsor fit, trendy, simple story if MCP is already working	Runtime MCP/setup ambiguity can eat solo time	Second-best
ChatSDK Agents	Strong engineering signal	Platform/webhook friction, weak voter clarity	Reject

Why Workflows wins: official materials emphasize durable, resumable execution and observability, and official templates already show the exact pattern judges respect—research, structured categorization, and human approval. OfferProof only needs **one** durable workflow, not a giant automation plant.

Final concept

OfferProof

Hook: *Before you apply, get proof.*

User: students, fresh grads, and junior professionals searching roles in Manila / SEA.

Agent action: parse job intent, fetch live job results, verify company footprint, scan recent news, score fit + risk, let the user keep/remove jobs, export a shortlist.

Why it wins: It attacks a real local pain, produces a clear red/yellow/green screenshot, uses real-time data, and turns “AI agent” from vague magic into a visible evidence pipeline. The emotional payoff is high: *it saves you from wasting time or getting burned.*

Demo theatre

Idea	10s hook	30s beat	5m flow	Backup
OfferProof	“Everyone knows a bad job post. This catches them before you apply.”	Enter “junior frontend Manila”; step chips fire; 2 red, 3 green cards appear	query → workflow → evidence drawer → remove one job → export shortlist	Seeded query + demo mode
ScamSignal	“Paste any sketchy link. Get a verdict with receipts.”	Paste a URL; search + news + company signals; risk card	input → scan → risk evidence → share card	Preloaded suspicious sample
BarangayReady	“Type your barangay; get a storm-day action pack.”	Enter location; nearest essentials + official updates + checklist	location → verify sources → kit → export	Static locality demo

MVP, reliability, and launch

Ugly but wins roadmap

Stage	Must-have
2h	Landing, query form, seeded result cards, one live Jobs lookup
6h	Jobs + Local + News enrichers, structured score, colored verdict cards
12h	Single Workflow run, evidence drawer, keep/remove approval, export card
1.0	Mobile polish, demo mode, screenshots, README, submission copy
1.1	Motion polish only

Kill list: auth, accounts, resumes/OCR, maps, Slack, multi-user history, fancy analytics, custom DB unless absolutely needed. v0 can handle full-stack Next.js, external APIs, GitHub branching, and one-click publish, so use it aggressively for shell/UI and keep custom code for agent logic only.

Reliability and fallback plan

Failure	Fallback
SerpApi quota / rate limit	Cache last-success results; identical Jobs queries can reuse free cached responses
Slow API	Show step skeletons + “search in progress”; reveal partial cards
No results	Suggest nearby city / remote toggle / broader role chip
Model confusion	Never let model invent listings; only score retrieved evidence
Deployment break	<code>/demo</code> route with frozen JSON + prerecorded GIF
Submission-day panic	Freeze features 24h before submit

Submission conversion audit

Title: OfferProof — AI agent that finds legit jobs and flags sketchy ones

First line: Paste a role or job post; OfferProof searches live listings, checks company footprint and recent news, then gives you an evidence-backed shortlist.

Hero screenshot: left = query + workflow timeline, right = three green/yellow/red job cards with evidence count.

GIF: query → steps running → two risky jobs disappear → shortlist export.

Technical proof paragraph: Built with Next.js, v0-generated UI, Vercel AI SDK structured outputs, one Vercel Workflow for deterministic multi-step verification, and SerpApi Jobs/News/Local for real-time evidence.

Vote CTA: *If this would have saved you one bad apply, vote for OfferProof.*

Social distribution and vote campaign

Channel	Timing	Copy
TikTok/Reel	submit day	"Job hunting is messy. I built an agent that finds real jobs and flags sketchy ones with receipts."
X	submit day	"Built OfferProof for Zero to Agent: live job search + company/news verification + red-flag score."
LinkedIn	submit day	"Solo-built a Vercel agent that helps candidates avoid bad applies and focus on evidence-backed roles."
Discord/class GC	voting day	"I built something real for job hunting—vote only if the demo earns it."
Vercel comment	voting day	"Happy to answer about Workflow + AI SDK + SerpApi design choices."

The tone should feel earned, not needy; that matters in a one-day vote window.

The execution window is driven by the official rules and the Manila/PT spread.

```
timeline
  title OfferProof execution plan
  2026-04-25 : Lock concept, draft PRD in v0, build landing + input
  2026-04-26 : Implement Jobs lookup + seeded demo JSON
  2026-04-27 : Add Local/News verification + structured scoring
  2026-04-28 : Add single Workflow run + evidence drawer
  2026-04-29 : Add export card + mobile/error states
  2026-04-30 : Record demo, screenshots, cover image
  2026-05-01 : Write README + submission copy
  2026-05-02 : Dry-run live demo + fallback checks
  2026-05-03 : Submit before 23:59 PT
  2026-05-04 : Vote push at open, mid, late window
```

Red-team and final recommendation

Top five critiques

Idea	Why it may lose	Defense
OfferProof	Could look like a job board clone	Make evidence, risk score, and trust cards the hero
ScamSignal	Too broad, harder to prove	Narrow to jobs/listings first

Idea	Why it may lose	Defense
BarangayReady	Safety-critical accuracy risk	Keep it to preparedness + official links, not evacuation authority
ClientProof	Narrower audience	Good backup, weaker public vote
RentProof	Nice, but slower payoff	Better as sequel, not main entry

Final recommendation

Build: OfferProof

Track: Workflows

Stack: Next.js App Router, TypeScript, Tailwind, shadcn/ui, v0, Vercel AI SDK + AI Gateway, one Vercel Workflow, SerpApi Google Jobs + Google News + Google Local, localStorage history, no auth.

MVP scope: one query, one visible workflow, one structured shortlist, one evidence drawer, one keep/remove approval, one export card, one demo mode.

5-minute demo: query → agent steps → live Jobs pull → company/news verification → green/yellow/red shortlist → remove one risky job → export “3 jobs worth applying to today.”

15s script: “Paste a job query. OfferProof finds live openings, checks the company, flags sketchy ones, and gives you a real shortlist.”

First v0 prompt

```
Build "OfferProof," a production-ready Next.js app for Zero to Agent.
Purpose: user enters a job role/location or pastes a job post; the app runs a 4-
step agent workflow:
1) fetch live job listings,
2) verify company footprint,
3) scan recent news,
4) produce a structured fit-and-risk shortlist.
Requirements:
- Tailwind + shadcn/ui
- one-screen hero demo
- visible step timeline
- red/yellow/green result cards
- evidence drawer with source links
- keep/remove approval interaction
- export shortlist as image/card
- no auth
- demo mode with seeded JSON fallback
- ready for Vercel deployment
First output only: PRD, route map, component tree, server actions/API plan,
workflow step plan, data schema, fallback plan, and build order. Do not generate
code yet.
```

Next 10 actions

1. Lock OfferProof.
2. Run the v0 PRD prompt.
3. Generate landing + input shell.
4. Wire Google Jobs route first.
5. Add structured score schema.
6. Add News + Local verification.
7. Wrap the sequence in one Workflow.
8. Build evidence drawer + export.
9. Create `/demo` seeded route.
10. Record 15s, 60s, and 5m demos before final polish.

Forgotten edge summary:

Biggest miss: optimizing build steps instead of selection psychology.

Biggest opportunity: trust-safety + careers is still wide open.

Biggest hidden risk: a strong build with weak launch assets still loses on May 4.

Fastest way to look like a winner: show one painful problem, one live workflow, and one screenshot-worthy verdict.

Fastest way to lose: build a generic assistant and explain it with jargon.

Mantra: *Don't build more AI; build one decision people are scared to get wrong.*
